

represented Philip's hopes to extend and develop that power. Reportedly, when Alexander complained that Philip had too many children, Philip advised him to struggle for first place, and to study hard:

Well then, if you have many competitors for the kingdom, prove yourself honourable and good, so that you might obtain the kingdom not because of me, but because of yourself. He bade Alexander give heed to Aristotle, and study philosophy, so that as he said, 'you may not do a great many things of the sort that I am sorry to have done'.

PLUTARCH, *SAYINGS OF KINGS AND COMMANDERS*

Education

Philip brought teachers to Macedonia for Alexander. Olympias' uncle Leonidas, a severe disciplinarian, was selected to tutor him. Leonidas intro-

duced Alexander to the rigours of military life with a lean diet, thin clothing and hard exercise. At thirteen, Alexander's education was taken over by the philosopher Aristotle, who instilled a scientific curiosity in subjects such as botany, zoology and medicine in the young prince. He was taught rhetoric and studied philosophy, which dealt with topics such as law, statecraft and personal ethics. Alexander diverged from Aristotle's teachings in only one respect. Aristotle taught that non-Greeks should be regarded as barbarians, inferior to Greeks; Alexander could hardly keep this belief as king of a multicultural empire like the Persian Empire.

Appointed regent

At sixteen, Alexander was appointed regent while his father fought in

Thrace. This was his first real taste of political and military power. He showed his ability by defeating a rebellious tribe, the Maedi, and founding a town, Alexandropolis, to keep the region under Macedonian control and to protect the supply routes into eastern Thrace. He was later given the task of capturing some southern Thracian cities and is reported to have saved Philip's life, probably at Perinthus.

In 339BC, under Philip's orders, Alexander mobilised the Macedonian army and stopped an invasion of Macedon by the Illyrians. In 338BC he commanded the Companion cavalry at Chaeronea, where he was first to break the enemy line. Philip chose him to head the embassy to Athens where he demonstrated diplomatic skill. In 336BC, upon Philip's assassination, Alexander became king of Macedon.

Social position and status

Alexander was born into the Macedonian family known as the Argeadae. The Macedonian monarchy was normally held by this family.

Power of the king

E Borza in *The Emergence of Macedon* argues that a Macedonian king had largely unrestricted personal powers. The king controlled natural resources such as gold and timber and probably land ownership. He controlled foreign alliances and made all decisions regarding foreign policy. He was the commander-in-chief of the Macedonian army and navy and had absolute power over these forces. He may also have had the right to declare war or make peace. He had the power to act as a judge in most cases, and was responsible for supervising religious rituals and festivals such as the festival of the Heracleidae. Finally it

appears that the king could appoint a successor.

The Macedonian aristocracy

The Macedonian aristocracy, wealthy or powerful families such as that of Attalus, supported the king in his actions and government. Many Macedonian kings died by assassination; the Macedonian aristocrats were not always loyal. From this group of families the king selected his Companions or Hetairoi. These men acted as advisers and officers in the army. They mixed socially in symposium or drinking parties, where they ate and drank a lot and discussed political and military issues. One symposium in 327BC resulted in the murder of Cleitus the Black by Alexander, who was drunk. The symposium acted as an informal political council and the king was under no obligation to

do as it suggested, although it was unwise not to.

Power of the army

The Macedonian army acted occasionally as an assembly of the people of Macedon. Only men had a say in the Macedonian government. As in the Greek states to the south, women had no direct political power and could not vote or be involved in decision-making. Olympias, however, obviously influenced politics indirectly. The Macedonian army could, according to Borza, be used to acclaim a new king—not elect one. This meant that they simply applauded the choice made by the old king and showed their acceptance of the new king. Occasionally the army could also act as a court to try cases such as treason, as shown in the trial of Philotas in 330BC.